

He was shouted down, with the Government producing its own census figure and claiming that Chundawat was raising the bogey of missing tigers only because he had been slapped with a hefty fine by the Forest Department for the use of an elephant. The animal, the Government said, had been sought for scientific research but was used to shoot a commercial documentary instead.

It is now clear that in Chundawat's case, Madhya Pradesh wildlife authorities, in a desperate bid to cover up their own sins, were merely shooting the messenger. It worked for four years but the shocking neglect and apathy have finally caught up with the state's Forest Department.

Early this year, a Ministry of Environment and Forests (MOEF) team found signs of tiger habitation in Panna but failed to sight the big cat. Their experience confirmed the version of local tour operators that tiger sightings had dwindled alarmingly. In March, experts from WII, who were camping in Panna to carry out a census, tentatively confirmed the worst fears of conservationists—at the most only one tiger was left there.

The decision to relocate tigresses from Bandhavgarh and Kanha to Panna was then made, a tacit admission by the department that the big cat had been run out or hunted down from Panna's forests. A local now says that one of the tigresses brought in to the reserve was already pregnant. This, he says, was a deception devised by forest officials to allow them to claim that there was a male tiger in Panna, when, in his estimation, the last tiger disappeared from Panna in 2008. The reason behind

Sariska's Successors

Nine other tiger reserves are "troubled" zones for the big cat



Source: National Tiger Conservation Authority
Graphics by PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

their disappearance was most probably unchecked poaching. If the tigers had left the habitat due to an imbalance in the natural cycle, relocated tigers would leave too.

Even as the NTCA formed the SIT to investigate the Panna episode, the MOEF wrote to the Madhya Pradesh Government, suggesting that a committee be formed to probe the tiger disappearances from Panna. Meanwhile, the state Government is targeting Sen for allowing the news of the purge of Panna into the public domain. Rather than introspect on his department's negligence, Additional Chief Secretary, Forests, Prashant Mehta, has written to the Centre, complaining that the SIT shouldn't have made such disclosures publicly. The

messenger has already been shot.

The Wildlife Crime Control Bureau, created at the behest of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh by amending the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, has seemingly failed to rein in poaching and related offences. A year after it was founded on June 6, 2007, the bureau is still grappling with manpower issues. Against a sanctioned staff of 110, only 25 personnel have been recruited. Rina Mitra, chief of the bureau, says, "It has been a bumpy ride to integrate forest, police and customs officials to combat wildlife crimes." The state Government has set up a separate probe committee for Panna, which is yet to begin investigations. This slow response reflects the establishment's attitude to the alarming rate at which the tiger is being hunted down.

The problem continues to grow: there have been six unexplained deaths in the state's Kanha Tiger Reserve. "Kanha is showing early signs of Panna," warns Chundawat. Tiger country is slowly but surely losing its stripes. ■



“Poachers visit the same locations periodically and become active when there is an administrative reshuffle of the brass of a national park or sanctuary.”

BELINDA WRIGHT, Executive Director, WPSI